

Proverbs 1:1–7 — PT Analysis and Revision

Notes

Sermon 2 in the Proverbs series · pulpit text NIV84 · checked against WLC Hebrew and the NIV84 Logos export in _texts/, and against dig-deeper-proverbs-1-1to7, point-purpose-proverbs-1-1to7 and the series point-purpose.

1. Opening summary

This is a sermon built on the text. It follows the passage's own order (the heading in v.1, the purpose statement in vv.2–6, the motto in v.7), and it ends with a link to Christ that comes from the passage's own words rather than from a jump to another text. Every one of the five “keep honest” warnings in the point-purpose is already dealt with: both halves of v.7 are preached; “beginning” is not treated as the beginners' stage; v.6 is kept in; the preacher places himself among “the simple”; and Solomon is presented as a warning, not a hero. Most of the gains available are in *coherence* and *landing*, not in direction.

2. What is working well

- **Cooper — reading the author's choices.** The v.2 / v.5 bracket, v.3b as the *manner* in which everything else is done, v.7 held back to the end, and the 9:4 / 9:16 identical invitation are all observations about how the book is put together. Anyone reading carefully could see them for themselves.
- **Davies — hearing the text's own purpose.** The passage contains no commands. The sermon does not invent any. It lets the passage *place* the hearer (“you are the simple”), and that is the application the passage is built to deliver.

- **The 22:6 paragraph.** This is the most pastorally valuable page in the sermon. It shows what v.6 protects the congregation from, and it speaks with the authority of someone who has lived it. Keep it.
- **Styles — reaching Christ from the text.** Isaiah 11:2–4 uses all four key terms of the preamble and also contains “not by what he sees with his eyes”. In Hebrew *ʿênāyw* is the same word as the book’s *bəʿênāyw* (checked in WLC), and “righteousness ... equity” in 11:4 (*ṣedeq ... mîšôr*) echo 1:3 (*ṣedeq ... mēšārîm*). This is a link the passage earns, not a bouncing ball.
- **Series link.** The big question is asked early and answered at the end, and the answer moves on from sermon 1.

3. Where the framework is not fully applied

(a) The “them then” is only mentioned, never pictured (*missed opportunity*). The sermon talks about the reader in general, never the first hearer. Davies’ structure needs a *them then* in the introduction and again in the conclusion. *Revision*: a young Israelite about to step out of his father’s house into the market, the law court and the city gate — places full of voices (1:8, 11–14, 20–21) — introduced after the opening illustration and brought back before the final application.

(b) Four questions risk becoming four separate points (*Davies’ warning*). “Whose / for whom / what asked / where begin” is faithful to the text, but nothing held the four together except the list. *Revision*: the thread of voices (the gang, Wisdom and Folly, the voice we can trust) and the verb “for giving” (v.4) now run through every movement, so the whole sermon drives towards one purpose.

(c) The gift in v.4 was not stressed (*important*). The point-purpose’s anti-moralism check turns on *lātēt*, “to give”. The original closed with “stop trusting our own eyes, start fearing the LORD, and listen...”, three

instructions with little ground under them. That is the “so be wise” ending the dig warns against. *Revision*: “for *giving*” is picked out in movement 2 and again in the conclusion, and the final lines rest the call on the gift: “Go to the King, and let him give you what you haven’t got. He gives wisdom to the simple.”

(d) The strongest bracket in the passage was missed. Verse 2 opens with “wisdom and discipline” and v.7 closes with “wisdom and discipline” (*ḥokmâ ûmûsâr* in both; the NIV84 keeps the pair in both places). This is headline finding 1 of the dig, and the pulpit text carries it. *Revision*: added to movement 4. What the book offers in v.2 is exactly what fools turn down in v.7.

(e) Factual and textual corrections.

Original	Problem	Revision
“Matthew 12:47”	Wrong reference	Matthew 12:42
“Verse 3 has ‘understanding’ and ‘insight’”	Both words are in v.2 (<i>lāhābîn ... bînâ</i>)	“Verse 2 talked about ‘wisdom’ and ‘understanding... insight’”
“verse 7... is the conclusion of the long sentence that began in verse 1”	v.7 has no connecting word (asyndetic); the dig calls it “dropped in like a foundation stone”	“Verse 7 also stands on its own... dropped in like a foundation stone”
Isa 11:2 quoted with “and he will delight...” attached	That clause is v.3a	Verses 2, 3 and 4 quoted separately
“1 Kings 11: ‘his wives led him astray’”	Correct wording (NIV84 11:3); verse number added	“1 Kings 11 verse 3”
“nine verses later... a gang’s recruitment speech”	The speech is 1:11–14	“a few verses later” with the reference
“at the hinge of the book in 9:10”	9:10 closes the opening section, chs 1–9	“at the end of the opening section”
“we’ve have prayed”	Typo	“we have prayed”
“bible teacher” (Goldingay)	Removed; the point now stands on the text	—

(f) Pulpit-text check. Every argument in the revision works in the NIV84 as read aloud: “wisdom and discipline” (1:2, 7), “for giving” (1:4), the identical words at 9:4 and 9:16, “his eyes” (Isa 11:3), “shrewd as snakes” (Matt 10:16). The one point the NIV84 hides (21:2, “seem right to him” for *in his own eyes*) is explained in the sermon, as before. NIV84 quotations follow the Logos export word for word, including “judgment”.

4. The deepest missed opportunity

Receiving, not achieving. The passage is a gift from start to finish. It has five verses of offer and one line of warning, and the key verb is “to give”. The original preached the diagnosis well but ended by telling the congregation what to do. The PT framework, and especially Styles, wants the Christ-landing to be the *ground* of the response: the King on whom the Spirit of wisdom rests is God’s wisdom *given*. The revision makes that the last word.

5. Summary judgement

This preacher reads the text closely, handles genre carefully and knows how to pastor people. The instincts for faithful exposition are all there. Taking the PT framework further here means three things: picture the first hearers, tie the four movements together with a single thread, and let the gift in v.4 carry the ending, so that the call to fear the LORD is received as good news rather than as one more thing to do.

6. Seven-second sermon plan (Davies)

Question?

I’m easier to talk round than I think, and I can’t reliably tell a true voice from a false one. How would I know if I were actually wise? (Them then: a young Israelite heading for the city gate, surrounded by voices he cannot yet sort out.)

Answer!

Proverbs is written for the simple, not the expert. It offers as a gift what they lack, asks to be read with care, and rests everything on the fear of the LORD, the very thing Solomon let go of and the promised King delights in.

So what...

Stop checking yourself with your own eyes. Admit that you are the person this book is for, and go to the King who never judged by his eyes, to be given the wisdom you haven't got.

Sermon structure produced by the plan

1. **Us now:** the “Hi Mum” text. We are more easily persuaded than we think. Series question; recap of sermon 1 (the certificates).
2. **Them then:** the young Israelite and the voices of the city.
3. **Body:** *Whose book?* (v.1: Solomon, gift and failure) → *Who for?* (vv.2–5: the simple; “for giving”; right, just and fair as the manner; the snake’s sharpness made clean; two voices, one invitation; the bracket to the wise) → *What asked?* (v.6: riddles; 26:4–5; 22:6) → *Where begin?* (v.7: “wisdom and discipline” bracket; foundation and top of the building; 3:7; 21:2) → *The King who does not judge by his eyes* (Isa 11:2–4; Matt 12:42).
4. **Them then:** the young man does not have to out-think every voice at the gate. He has to fear the LORD and listen to the LORD’s voice.
5. **Us now:** the answer for this week (“we start by admitting we are the people this book is for”); the confident, the easily led, the not-yet-Christian; the “Hi Mum” callback; hand-over to chapter 2 (2:6, “the LORD gives wisdom”).

7. The illustration

Chosen: the “Hi Mum” text scam. Most people in the congregation, teenagers included, will know it or will have had one. It suits this passage in three ways:

- **It is about a voice, not a picture.** The FCF is *we cannot tell a good voice from a bad one*. The parasol story was about a misleading photograph, which is a real but different failure. The scam text *sounds* like the person you love, just as Folly (9:16) uses Wisdom’s exact words (9:4).
- **Its victims are not stupid.** That matches “the simple” = *open*, not *dim*.
- **The cure is outside yourself.** The official advice is not “read the message more carefully” but “ring the number you already know”. That is the sermon’s own answer: not sharper eyes, but a trusted voice. It also matches sermon 1 (someone else marks the paper).

The callback (conclusion): “The advice wasn’t, ‘Study the message harder.’ It was, ‘Ring the number you already know. Hear the real voice.’ ... We have been given a voice we can trust.”

If you would rather keep the parasols, it is a warm personal story and works well as a short aside in the introduction (around 60 words). But it should not carry the closing, because ten-inch parasols make people smile and don’t bear the weight of the final call.

8. Vocabulary (aimed at a 14-year-old)

- **Explained where the NIV84 uses them:** *prudence* (“the good sense to spot a trap before you walk into it”), *discretion* (“the ability to see what someone is really after”), *the simple* (“open... the door is always unlocked”), *fear of the LORD* (“take God seriously: be in awe of him, trust him, let him correct us”).

- **Replaced:** *programme, self-sufficient, vulnerable, self-examination, the summit, welded together, drumbeat, precisely, share a root* (now “the same word family”), *diagnosis*.
- **Hebrew:** no Hebrew word needs to be read aloud. Each point is made in English (“in Hebrew, ‘his eyes’ is the very same word”).

9. Figures

	Original	Revised
Words, title to “Amen” (including Scripture)	2,532	≈2,700–2,740 (2,701 <i>excluding stand-alone dashes</i>)
Flesch–Kincaid grade (approx.)	4.4	3.9
Flesch reading ease (approx.)	85	88
Likely delivery (at 120–130 wpm)	20–21 min	21–23 min, plus the readings
A5 pages	—	11

Readability figures use a standard syllable estimate. They confirm the sentences are short; the vocabulary list above is the more reliable check for a 14-year-old.

10. Publication summary

How would you know if you were actually wise? Proverbs opens by naming its readers – not the experts, but “the simple”: people easily talked round, who believe whoever spoke last. Solomon’s name is on the cover, but he is the book’s warning, not its hero. This sermon works through Proverbs 1:1–7 to its foundation stone, the fear of the LORD, and lands on Isaiah’s promised King – the one who does not judge by what he sees with his eyes.